



**PAWAR
CAMPAIGNS
FOR HIS
PARTY**

if at all, only after the polls.

With Pawar's party facing the wrath of local leaders in the sugar belt, projections are not looking favourable for the NCP as it is likely to garner 50 to 55 seats. If this projection proves to be true, then the NCP's very existence will be at risk as the Congress will return to playing big brother if it goes past 100 seats. Also, Pawar will be faced with large-scale defections if his party does not do well. Unlike the Lok Sabha elections, this time the NCP is doing all it can to curtail rebels within its own party. Says its spokesperson Madan Bafna: "We took some internal disputes and local fights lightly last year, which is why we fared badly. But this time we are taking everything very seriously. It's a fact that NCP workers are very upset about our contesting only 114 seats when we are

SHARAD PAWAR

The political veteran is facing his toughest battle yet

↑ Pawar is a master at managing elections and crises. He has opened talks with the Shiv Sena for an alliance in case the BJP does not win enough seats to get a majority. The rise of the MNS will split the saffron vote and help the secular alliance score.

↓ The misrule by several NCP ministers has wiped out the party from western Maharashtra, its strongest bastion. It is a do-or-die election for him as pressure to merge with the Congress will increase if the party fails to win more than 50 seats.

working all over Maharashtra. But still rebellion is not such an issue for us."

Anticipating a situation where the Congress would spark defections within the NCP after elections, Pawar has an alternative plan in place. By talking about his retirement, he is making it clear to the Congress that he is open to giving up his cabinet berth at the Centre, if it means teaching the Congress a lesson in Maharashtra. And to achieve this end, the old fox has opened talks with the Shiv Sena for an alliance in case the BJP is not able to get enough seats to get a majority and the NCP is being bullied by the Congress. In such a scenario, the NCP will break away from the Congress and join hands with the Shiv Sena. Call it pressure tactics if you will, but Pawar is known to keep his options open and his rivals guessing.

What he is doing to the Congress, Raj and Rane are doing to the Shiv Sena. With the two key defectors from the Sena working towards defeating the Sena candidates, this is a battle for prestige for Uddhav as he tries to bring diverse people into the party. In key urban constituencies, the MNS and Congress have reached a quiet understanding to work together to defeat the Sena candidates. In these elections, the MNS is doing its best to increase its nuisance value by selling out to the highest bidder. A key example of this is the Mahim seat where the Sena has fielded Adesh Bandekar, a Marathi actor, in place of its sitting MLA Sada Sarvankar. With Rane having gotten a Congress ticket for Sarvankar and the MNS putting its might behind its candidate Nitin Sardesai, Uddhav may find it